

Originally, I started feeling drawn towards ideas of the pigeon, what they represented in New York Culture (flying rats), and what it says about how we dominate and treat animals and nature as a whole. But over the course of the coming weeks, I had trouble clarifying and developing my concepts—continuously finding myself stumped by the “cosplay” and “tacky” idea of a giant pigeon head. Through some reflection, I evaluated why I wanted to join this course in the first place. To create garments and to understand the basics of the sewing machine.

It is with this understanding that I explored the idea of making a hoodie. Something that I would wear to some art event, and to stir up some type of reaction. I also wanted to fully utilize the materials (wool) from the cocoon project from last semester.

I am drawn to wool material for many reasons. Personally, I wanted to keep the material that I’ve worked so hard on creating, creating a product from something that took me so much time and energy to felt so that I can keep it forever. However, conceptually I am still drawn to the idea of humans dominating nature, or more specifically animals. The hoodie would be made of wool, and I wanted to imagine literally or more overtly wearing a sheep’s “skin” (while wool could be sheared off, most if not all sheep only create wool as a byproduct and are many times even treated as a “cost” since they need to be sheared for health reasons). The wool that I’m wearing would be what’s left of a presumably “slaughtered” sheep. Keeping with the “wearing the skin of an animal” theme from the pigeon concept, I am now wearing the “skin” of a sheep.

Sheep typically represent pureness, innocence, and cleanliness. However, the fate of the sheep in factory farms is far from it. The blood on the hoodie evokes many symbolism, but most apparently it evokes that of roadkill. Like roadkill, we are negligent to the death of these animals, and like roadkill, their carcasses are cast aside. This all supports a subtle narrative pointing at the cost of our casual garments. Instead of cleaning and hiding the ugliness and natural accumulation of dirt, grass and seeds, I embrace and show it. Whether that is to honor the sheep by not forgetting the dirt that it comes from, or to embrace the wilderness and connect back with nature – as this is a garment sewn by myself and not bought from mass production lines.

The sewing of the garment by myself also supports the idea that we should have more care and intention with how we treat the things we typically dominate and wear. I am not against the killing of animals for food or other products, but we must consume with intention and understanding of where it comes from (and then decide with clarity whether or not we still want to consume it)